Ghazna and Bust–Lashkari Bazar[14]

The multi-faceted significances of the Shansabani conquest of Ghazna cannot be sufficiently emphasized. This event was pivotal in the Shansabanis' overarching historical trajectory: the taking of the city certainly resulted in the irretrievable (if painfully gradual) demise of the Yamini–Ghaznavids, and the eradication of the Oghüz nomads from Zabulistan and Zamindawar introduced new horizons for Shansabani territorial expansion. And as already noted, the establishment of the collateral Shansabani lineage at the old Yamini capital not only expanded the Shansabani confederacy, it opened the way to India.

This chapter argues that the conquest of Ghazna could have had additional, meaningful consequences on a more intimate plane: the architectural remains at Ghazna and its attendant regions evince signs of a shift in lifeways for the new Shansabani lineage *vis-à-vis* their Firuzkuh cousins – a shift toward greater sedentism, which would also echo in the architectural remnants of their campaigns beyond the Indus into the north Indian plains (see this Volume's Introduction, and Volume II).

However, akin to the archaeological remains at Jam-Firuzkuh (cf. Chapters 3 and 4), any analysis of the documented architectural fabric as well as the still to be studied material remains of Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar also requires important caveats. It bears reiterating that the Mongol campaigns along the Zabulistan–Zamindawar corridor (map, p. xvi) and their various aftermaths, unfolding during the third through eighth decades of the thirteenth century, certainly disturbed what had survived of these urban and palatial sites' historical remnants.[15] In addition, given their multiple occupational layers, the Ghaznavid sites of southern Afghanistan comprised vast archaeological complexes requiring collaboration among a range of specialists from the pre-Islamic centuries onward. The sheer scale of these sites has meant that, despite many seasons of survey and excavation – cumulatively spanning the 1920s through 1970s[16] – they were worked upon only partially before political and military insecurity in Afghanistan made work there extremely difficult, if not impossible. Thus, like Jam-Firuzkuh, what is presented here must be viewed as provisional, until exploration in these areas can be reinitiated.

There are nonetheless important observations that *can* be made. Archaeological and art-historical analyses of the remains of Ghazna and Bust–Lashkari Bazar certainly revealed distinguishable phases of architectural intervention at these localities. As discussed in detail below, the generally accepted sequence of events is that the existing Ghaznavid-period buildings and complexes at Ghazna and Lashkari Bazar – Bust having been less studied – suffered partial destruction by fire. At Lashkari Bazar the destruction was evidenced on two occasions, the first attributable to 'Ala' al-Din *Jahan-suz*'s sacking in AH 544/1150 CE, and the second perhaps to